Effective Presentation Strategies

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INTRODUCTION

Whether you work in a business organization or an educational institution, or you are a student, it is essential that you possess good public speaking skills. Throughout your career, you are bound to encounter innumerable situations which demand effective presentations. To mention a few, as a team leader you may have to present before the corporate body, a product which your team has brought out; as one of the top administrators of your institution, you may have to present the goals, activities, and achievements of your institution to an important visitor; as project manager you may have to present before a committee the results of a project recently undertaken by your company, and so on. In addition, as a student you may have to attend seminars or you may have to present your project reports to your fellow students and faculty members. These situations call for effective, memorable presentations. Though these circumstances differ in purpose, the strategies you need to make good presentations do not differ much.

The ability to make effective and memorable oral presentations is one of the most important qualities you need to develop for a successful career. Constant practice is the key to acquiring this skill.

'Half the world is composed of people who have something to say and can't, and the other half, who have nothing to say and keep on saying it.'

Robert Frost

The more successful your career, the more often you will be called upon to make presentations for a variety of situations and audiences. Let us look at certain fundamentals of professional presentations, which will help you to become an effective presenter.

DEFINING PURPOSE

The purpose of your presentation not only decides the content and style but also affects the amount of audience interaction. For instance, when your purpose is to provide information or to analyse a situation, you and the audience generally interact in a limited manner. Say, you want to present the *control of operations* or *implementation of policies and procedures* or *the status of work* to the respective audiences; they may ask questions or offer suggestions.

On the other hand, when your purpose is to persuade people to take a particular action, or to collaborate with them in solving a problem, or making a decision, the interaction would be more. You generally begin by providing facts and figures that increase your audience's understanding of the subject; you might also offer arguments in defence of certain conclusions and recommendations. In addition, you invite them to participate by expressing their need, suggesting solutions, and formulating conclusions and recommendations. However, this would need a lot of 'on-the-spot' thinking skills and in-depth knowledge of the subject. Depending upon your purpose—to inform, to analyse, or to persuade—you should be flexible enough to adjust to new input and unexpected audience reactions.

ANALYSING AUDIENCE AND LOCALE

'It is a remarkable observation that the more learned and respected the researcher, the simpler their talks often seem to be.'

Mike Grimble

All audiences have one thing in common. They are at the receiving end of your communication. They may be your friends, foes, clients, colleagues, sometimes unfamiliar faces, or a medley of all these. The nature of your audience has a direct impact on the strategy you devise for your presentation. Hence it is necessary to have some prior knowledge of the audience's characteristics. If you are going to speak before an unknown group, ask your host or an organiser for help in analysing the audience; supplement their estimates with some intelligent guesstimates of your own.

Know Your Audience

- What are their interests, likes, and dislikes?
- Are they familiar with the topic?
- Is their attitude hostile or friendly?
- What's the size of the group?
- Age range? Gender distribution?

Whether you present locally or in a foreign country, you can expect at least some members to have linguistic or cultural backgrounds different from your own. Those who are not very conversant with English or with your accent will appreciate relatively slow speech and visual aids designed to aid their understanding. You should also adjust your style to accommodate cultural

differences. For instance, people from a particular culture may feel uncomfortable asking questions or may not reveal their feelings through facial expressions. If you know in advance how your audience is likely to react, you can structure your presentation and adapt your style to help them feel comfortable. You too are less likely to feel distressed by their reactions.

If your target audience is from your own organization, you will already have information about their characteristics. Estimate their interests, likes, and dislikes, determine their degree of knowledge of the topic, know whether there is hostility toward the topic or toward you, be aware of the gender of the group and approximate ages, and consider the size and composition of the audience. All the above steps are essential because you'll be gearing the style and content of the speech to your audience's background, needs, interests, and attitudes.

We communicate to inform, persuade, or entertain. Whatever may be the purpose, give the impression to your audience that you want to share your views with them. Fathom out their experience and knowledge of the subject matter. What do they know about the topic already? What more will they want to know about the topic? What do I want them to know by the end of my talk? Now prepare your material accordingly.

At the start of your presentation make eye contact with your audience. This will help you to assess whether they are excited, resistant, hostile, or dull. *Always begin with a smile* and greet them in a pleasant tone.

If you get the impression that they are not interested in what you are saying try to change your tone. Work to achieve effectiveness in your communication by responding to audience feedback. For example, you must watch for signs that your audience wants to interact, ask questions, or even to end your presentation. Even though they are well educated, don't go for words rarely used in conversation. Instead of creating a good impression, you will only confuse or irritate them. The more meticulous you are in your choice of words, the greater are the effects of your oral presentation. If you feel that the audience is not interested in your speech, try to catch their attention by giving it a personal tinge to which they can easily relate. Anecdotes can work wonders for the wandering attention of the audience.

Remember that while a person reading a written report can review what he has read, skip pages and go forward, or stop to ponder the meaning of words, a listener cannot replay what he misses when his attention wanders. Since it is inevitable that his attention will wander, you must prepare your presentation specifically for listeners. Even before the content is presented, the structure and organization of your presentation must be clear. Key points should be emphasized and repeated at appropriate moments.

The structure of a presentation can further be skillfully emphasized by pauses, through interactions with the audience, and through changes in delivery

techniques. You can also use visual aids to great effect to hold audience attention and promote understanding.

If you are going to speak about something controversial or you have to break bad news perhaps, set aside some time before your presentation to chat with those who will be affected. This will help you to:

- build support
- anticipate problems
- consider strategies

Testing the waters before hand, so to speak, will help you to fine-tune your approach.

Speak with confidence and conviction. Make your points crystal clear and easy to understand. Maintain an attitude of alertness and confidence. Encourage questions from audience. Audience participation gives the opportunity to clear up any misunderstanding.

In addition to an overall understanding of the audience you need to find out about the locale. Every location has its unique physical environment. You may present in magnificently large auditoriums or oppressively small conference rooms. Know the physical setting: find out whether you'll have a podium or a table, whether you'll have a public address system and so on. Also pay attention to the physical conditions confronting your audience such as seating, room temperature, and lighting. Have they been seated on hard metal chairs for an hour in a freezing room? Or is the lighting too powerful to render your slide presentation ineffective? If you identify such problems in advance, you can either ask for alternative arrangements or modify your materials, visual aids, and style to suit the environment.

ORGANIZING CONTENTS

People vary in their ability to speak confidently in public. When you face an audience you should expect to feel a little nervous. Without a little nervous excitement, you could end up making a dull, lifeless presentation. *Always prepare more material than required, as this will help you feel confident.* When you get on the stage, take your time to arrange your notes. Before you start speaking take a couple of deep breaths. Your first words will sound louder and more confident. The extra oxygen will also help you concentrate. Make eye contact with one person for a few seconds before you move up on to the next. Begin with a smile; by doing so you offer them a warm welcome that helps them and you to relax. If you are still a novice, memorize the first few sentences so that you can move ahead easily.

Arrange the contents of your presentation into three major parts namely, introduction, main body, and conclusions. In other words, *say what you want to say; say it; then say what you've already said.*

'Humour is just another defense against the universe.'

Mel Brooks

Ways to Control Anxiety

- **Make sure you are well-rehearsed**
  Panic sets in if you are not fully prepared. Work on your timing. Rehearse in front of a practice audience.

Warm up with relaxation exercises
Relax tense muscles with some simple exercises. This will help to avoid feeling nervous and shaky.

Expect the unexpected
Accept that things may not go according to plan. Keep your humour intact.

Introduction

The introduction comprises the porch or the opening statement, the aim, and the layout. The porch can be a question, a sincere greeting, or a starting statement. This catches the attention of your audience and prepares them to listen to the rest of your presentation. Depending upon the topic, you can use a question, a quotation, a statement, or even an anecdote to grab the attention of the audience. For example, if you deliver a presentation on the topic 'The New Performance Appraisal System', you can begin your presentation with the question: 'What are the benefits of the newly introduced performance appraisal system?' or with the statement, 'The new performance appraisal has brought in a lot of changes.'

Imagine that you are giving a presentation on the topic 'The Role of Emotional Intelligence in Developing Leadership Skills'. You can start your presentation with an anecdote similar to the one given below:

On Friday, when I was attending a meeting, I could barely control my open appreciation of Ms.Veena, the Chairperson. You may wonder why. I will tell you now. She was able to resolve the conflict between two participants amicably simply by using intelligence to understand their emotions. Yes, friends, in today's business world, emotional intelligence plays a very important role in cultivating various skills—leadership skill is one among them.

After the porch, state clearly and precisely the purpose of your presentation. For instance, it can be as pointed as this—'One reason brings me here today: to inform you about our new performance appraisal system.' End your introduction by giving an overview or road map of your presentation.

A good introduction is a vehicle to lead the audience into the main body of the speech. Consider the following example:

I am here to brief you about the details of this appraisal system. I will start by giving a brief idea about the earlier system and then proceed to discuss the highlights of the new system.

After giving a preview, make sure that you provide a smooth transition to the main body of the speech.

Among the highlights, let me begin with the most important one, that is, the frequency of appraisal.

Main body

The main body, the discussion, or the text part follows the subsequent to introduction and supports your aim or specific purpose. The major points you highlighted in your opening will be expanded upon here. Depending upon your topic, and your introduction, you can choose from any of the following patterns to organize the main body of your speech.

- **Chronological**
  You can have this pattern for organizing the details which you can arrange sequentially (in the order in which the events occurred or appeared before you). The entire presentation can be arranged chronologically. This method is useful for topics like 'the profile of your institute', 'the changing face of the earth', and 'history of sports'.
- **Categorical**
  This is one of the easiest and most commonly adopted patterns for many topics. The entire presentation can be divided into various topics and sub-topics arranged on the basis of subordination and coordination. This can be used for topics like 'the role of advertising', 'environmental protection', 'importance of professional presentation', etc.
- **Cause and effect**
  You can adopt this method whenever there exists a cause and effect relationship. Here you have to illustrate and explain the causes of the situation and then focus on the effects. It is relevant for topics like 'impact of cinema on children', 'internet—boon or bane', 'smoking in children', etc.
- **Problem-solution**
  Here you divide the presentation into two parts. In the first part describe and analyse the cause and effect of the problem. After the analysis you move on to the main objective of your presentation to suggest or propose a solution to the problem. It is a very helpful and effective way for persuasive presentation. For topics like 'populaion explosion' this method can be used.

You can bolster your argument or ideas by providing examples, illustrations, statistics, testimony, analogy, or definition.

Resist the temptation to include too many points in the body of your speech. Restrict yourself to four or five main points. You can help the audience follow your preparation by summarizing your points as you go along. Every main point is a unit of thought, an essential part of a speech. Each point should be clearly stated independent of other main points. Balance the time devoted to each point accordingly.

Plan how you will bridge on link points so that you move smoothly from one part of your presentation to the next. Make use of transitional expressions like therefore, because, in addition to, apart from that, on the contrary, next, etc. See Chapter 10 for details on transitional expressions.

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Internal previews, internal summaries and sign posts help not only you in understanding where you are in the speech, but also the audience in grasping the topic better. For example, you can say, 'before taking you through the advantages of the new appraisal system, let me just recapitulate what I had told you about the existing one. The existing appraisal system, in a nutshell, lacks important aspects such as the candidates' communication skills, their ability to motivate their subordinates and their analytical capabilities.' This statement would serve as an internal preview as well as an internal summary.

Similarly when you say, 'There are four advantages, as I had already said. Having discussed the first two of them, let me move on to the third advantage', the statement would serve as a *signpost* to tell the audience that you have completed two and there are two more to go.

Conclusions

You can conclude your presentation by reviewing the main points. Give a signal such as *to sum up, to conclude, to review*. As you conclude, remind the audience briefly about the purpose of your presentation, which could be either to persuade them or to inform them. Tell them what you want them to do, think, or remember based on your presentation.

Avoid the temptation to wrap up in haste or add something new in this part of your speech.

You can also conclude with a quotation or recall the earlier story, joke, anecdote with which you commenced your presentation to bring it to a full circle.

Very often, presentations are followed by a question period. Questions provide you with vital feedback about the ideas that you have put forth in your presentation. Preparing for questions, therefore, is as important as preparing for your presentation.

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How does a presenter cope with difficult questions? This is every presenter's nightmare, but one every seasoned speaker has to overcome to emerge more confident and self-assured. If a questioner tries to trip you up with a difficult question, maintain a polite but firm attitude. Do not reveal annoyance, but as soon as possible, divert to other members of the audience.

It is also important that you learn how to quickly divert irrelevant questions, so as to avoid wasting everybody's time. If any *one* person in the audience tries to

ng with Difficult Questions

ile preparing for the presentation, make a list of questions which you think your audience will ask and
tally prepare yourself to answer them.
ate when you are ready for questions.
' becoming defensive. Make questioners feel that their questions are welcome.
do not know the answer to a question, be truthful and say so. Admitting ignorance is better than
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efore you speak.

monopolise question time, you have to learn to handle that too by indicating that each questioner has to be given a fair chance.

PREPARING AN OUTLINE

An outline is a mechanical framework in which are fitted the bits and pieces of your presentation material. It serves as a guide to show you the right path for your presentation. So spending time in developing an outline never goes waste. In fact, you should use an outline as your 'script' but be prepared to deviate in response to audience feedback.

Suppose you are the project leader of a team, which has taken up a project on developing a new product for the company. You have to present before a committee the new product, which is going to be launched in the market. This may be a 10 minute presentation about the facilities the product offers, its functioning, etc. Your outline can be in the form of words, phrases, or sentences:

1. Introduction
2. Product Appearance
3. Various parts
4. Functioning
5. Facilities
6. Conclusions

You may have to work out the sub-headings under each or some of these main topics. But as already said, you should be ready to skip or add some topics if your audience wants you to do so.

VISUAL AIDS

Spoken words are ephemeral; as soon as they come out of our mouth they evaporate into the air. Because of this limitation, speeches often need strong visual support—handouts, chalk boards, flip chart, overheads, slides, computers, charts tables, film, etc. If a picture is simple, clear and appropriate to its purpose and audience it will deliver its message more accurately and quickly than a verba explanation. Ours is a visually oriented society and an audience likes to hear a

The importance of visual aids:

- increase audience interest;
- illustrate key points;
- signal transition from one part of the presentation to the next;
- increase impact of message;
- help listeners retain information;
- help you present ideas without depending on notes; and
- for those not familiar with your language or accent, turn the incomprehensible into something understandable

well as see information. Aeons ago Herodotus said that people trust their ears less than their eyes. His words ring true today as well.

When choosing visual aids select those which suit the style and content of your presentations. Try to get visual aids for any point that sounds vague and requires discussion in detail. Ensure that it is well designed and professionally generated. Do not use visual aids as a verbal crutch for the speaker!

The table given below provides you some tips pertaining to the types of visual aids you may commonly use in your presentation:

e 5.1: Visual Aids Used in Presentations

Type	Tips
Overhead Transparencies	• Use larger fonts. Avoid decorative fonts. • Separate the transparencies using sheets of paper. • Keep transparencies uncluttered. • Show only the required information. • Do not add multiple colours or exciting back drops to your slides. • Use pointer on the screen, or your pencil or pen on the transparency to draw audience's attention to a specific item. • Familiarize yourself with the operation of the overhead projector. • Be ready with your notes in case of power failures.
Power Point Presentations	• Check the computer system/equipment before loading. • Familiarize yourself with the operation of the slides. • Transfer your file to the hard disk. • Be familiar with the operation of slide show. • Rehearse your presentation. • Keep a printed copy of the slides (6 slides on a sheet of paper) for use in case of computer malfunction.
Blackboard or Whiteboard	• Clean the board well before starting and check the condition of markers. • Write in large letters. • Stand to the side as you write. • Don't face the board while talking to the audience. • Divide the board into columns and write legibly. • Keep contents which you may want to refer to again.
Flip Charts	• Use different coloured markers. • Keep two pads of paper. • Write in large letters. • Use only one side of the chart. • Wait for the audience to grasp the contents before turning pages.

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Be judicious in your choice of aids. If you are going to deliver a lecture to illiterate people, don't go for tables or complex graphs; instead use aids which they can understand. For instance, if you are talking about the working of the heart, make sure you show them some pictures, name all the parts, use a pointer to make it clear to them about which part of heart you are discussing. If you wish to use the visual aids of other organizations rather than your own, confirm beforehand the availability of those aids which you need.

Guidelines to make effective use of visual aids:

- If you feel that the audience needs explanation for your aids explain to them lest they should misunderstand it.
- Organize the visual aids as a part of the presentation. Fit them into the plan.
- Emphasize the visual aids. Point to them with bodily action and with words.
- Talk to the audience, not to the visual aids. Look at the visual aids only when the audience should look at them.
- Avoid blocking the listener's view of the visual aids. Make sure that lecterns, pillars, charts, and such don't block anyone's view. Take care not to stand in anyone's line of vision.
- Refrain from removing the aid before the audience has an opportunity to absorb the material.
- Do not talk about the visual aid after you have put it aside.
- Use enough visual aids to make your points clear, but don't overdo it.
- Don't use too many lines or figures on one aid, make sure that it's visible to one and all from all the corners of room.
- It should not be very light that the audience finds it hard to see. Too small an illustration will not be visible to those in the back of the audience.
- Keep them at an inconspicuous place, if aids are too many, or they may distract the attention of the audience.
- Be familiar with the basic operations of the electronic devices which you would use for your presentations.



Here are certain points that you should keep in mind while using visual aids. While delivering your speech use your visual aids when needed. As soon as you show something to the audience, make it a point to immediately explain it. If you have to say something beforehand, first complete your point and only then switch over to your visual aid. Otherwise the audience may be distracted from whatever you are saying.

UNDERSTANDING NUANCES OF DELIVERY

All of us have listened to more than our share of bad presentations. We have sat through presentations that were delivered so haltingly that we could not care what was being said. We would also have come across presentations which were delivered smoothly but which had practically put us to sleep, as the presenter droned on endlessly.

What is it that makes your presentation hold the attention and interest of your audience? Your manner of presentation, your vocal inflections, your perfectly timed pauses, your facial expressions, and your gestures. All these are part of an

expert delivery. Even a dull and drab topic will turn out to be more interesting if presented well, whereas a really interesting topic may appear to be dull because of poor delivery. So one thing becomes clear—*having something to say is not enough; you must also know how to say it.* Good delivery does not call attention to itself. It conveys your ideas clearly, interestingly and without distracting the audience. Most audiences prefer delivery that combines a certain degree of formality with the best attributes of good conversation—directness, spontaneity, animation, vocal and facial expressiveness, and a lively sense of communication.

There are four modes of delivery which can be used for making presentations:

- Extemporaneous
- Manuscript
- Impromptu
- Memorization

Extemporaneous

Extemporaneous presentation is by far the most popular and effective method when carefully prepared. When speaking extempore you must prepare the notes beforehand and rehearse your presentation. There is no need to learn every word and line by rote. Your presentation will sound quite spontaneous to the audience, as after thorough preparation, you are speaking while thinking. This is the result of assiduous planning and exacting practice, where you collect the material and organize it meticulously. Let us look at some of the positive and negative aspects of this mode of presentation.

Advantages

- As you have enough time to prepare for the presentation, you work hard on the theme/central idea. You can present the theme in the best possible structured way.
- Thorough preparation on your part makes you feel secure and you carry out your responsibility with great aplomb. Adaptation is also possible if the need arises. In other words, the language of any written text does not bind you. You can be flexible in your use of language.
- The supporting material helps to present your points clearly and also adds weight to your agreement. Appropriate selection of quotations, illustrations, statistics, etc. helps you to substantiate your point.
- Your delivery sounds natural and spontaneous to the audience as it allows you to establish a rapport with the audience through more eye contact.
- It enables one to move freely, with ease.

Disadvantages

- If preparation is inadequate, you can get lost and find yourself uncomfortable.

- If you rely too much on note cards and start reading out from them instead of just consulting them for reference, then your speech will lose its spontaneity.

Manuscript

In manuscript presentation, material is written out and you are supposed to read it out aloud verbatim. You are not supposed to memorize the speech and then recollect it. It's there in front of you to read. But, you should be wise enough not to attempt to read a speech until you have become a proficient reader. Unfortunately most speakers are not good readers. They make it uninteresting by reading in a dull and monotonous way. However, you *can* overcome this problem with consistent efforts. You could maybe rehearse with a friend or colleague.

For effective use of this mode, you should have gone through the material several times beforehand till you become absolutely familiar with the text. You should strive to choose material designed to achieve understanding. Do cultivate familiarity with speech/text. You should know *what* is written *where*.

Advantages

- It's a permanent and accurate record of whatever you have to say.
- There is no chance of tampering with the facts and figures.
- The material is organized systematically. Keep in mind the step-by-step development of main points.
- Language gets polished because you can write and rewrite your material until you feel satisfied on all counts.

Disadvantages

- Since you will be reading from the manuscript, you get less time for making proper eye contact, which is essential to feel the pulse of your audience.
- Since you are reading to the audience, you cannot talk to them. There is not much scope either for non-verbal communication.
- Adaptation is rather difficult, if the need arises, to give a different twist to your material.
- In the absence of effective reading skill, you fumble over words, lose your pace, and miss punctuation marks, etc. This adds up to an uninteresting speech and loss of audience attention.
- Conversational flavour along with vocal inflection takes a back seat here, which is a great asset for you as a speaker.

Impromptu

'It takes three weeks to prepare a good, impromptu speech.'

Mark Twain

The impromptu mode, as the word suggests, is what you use when you have to deliver an informal speech without preparation. For example, at a formal dinner party you may be invited to deliver a vote of thanks. Don't panic and babble something in an unmethodical way. Instead, calmly state your topic and then preview the points you are to make. Support your points with whatever examples,

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quotes, and anecdotes you recall at that time. Then briefly summarize or restate your points and end with a smile. Remember, it is not difficult for you to anticipate certain occasions where you may be asked to speak a few words. Be as brief as possible during your impromptu presentations.

Advantages

- You sound very natural because you do not get enough time to make any elaborate preparation.
- You get a chance to express your thoughts irrespective of what others think or say about that particular topic.
- You are spontaneous as you say what you feel, not what you ought to say.

Disadvantages

- The presentation lacks organized development of ideas because of the shortage of time.
- There is no supplementary material (no data, no statistics, no illustrations, no figures) to substantiate the speech.
- Chances of rambling are very high. Various points may hang loose.
- There is frequent use of vocalized pauses.
- The presentation may turn out to be a failure if you have inadequate proficiency in the language you use.

Bear in mind that gaining a reputation for being a good impromptu speaker can do a great deal for your career aspirations. It has been shown that there is a positive correlation between communication effectiveness and upward mobility. So do rise to the challenge!

Memorization

This method of presentation is very difficult for most of us. Probably only a handful of you can actually memorize an entire speech. Usually you memorize only the main parts and are in the habit of writing key words on your cards to help you out through the actual presentation. In some cases, if you wish to quote somebody or narrate an anecdote or a joke, it's better to memorize these for your presentations.

This type of delivery stands somewhere between extemporaneous and manuscript presentation. Speech is written out beforehand, then committed to memory, and finally delivered from memory.

Advantages

- It's very easy for such speakers to maintain an eye contact with the audience throughout the presentation.
- The speaker can easily move and make use of appropriate non-verbal communication to add extra value to the speech.
- It is possible to finish the speech in allotted time.

Disadvantages

- Memorization requires too much of time.
- There are chances of making it a dull and monotonous presentation because you go exactly by whatever you have memorized.
- Even your mnemonic skills fail you if you have not rehearsed adequately. (The use of mnemonics is explained in Chapter 8.)
- No flexibility or adaptation is possible during the speech.
- The speaker gets flustered if he forgets a word, sentence, or a whole paragraph.

Among all the four modes of delivery, extemporaneous is the best because of its flexible nature and its effectiveness. Hence it is always better to use this mode to make your presentations more lively, effective, and memorable.

KINESICS

'Nobility and dignity; self-abasement and servility, insolence and vulgarity, are reflected in the face and in the attitudes of the body whether still or in motion.'

Socrates

Kinesics is the name given to the study of the body's physical movements. In other words, it is the way the body communicates without words, i.e., through various movements of its parts. As is well said by Watzlawick and his associates, 'You cannot not communicate'. You communicate just by being. Nodding your head, blinking your eyes, shrugging shoulders, waving the hands, and other such physical activities are all forms of communication. Some kinesic behaviours are deliberately intended to communicate, as when you nod your head for acceptance. Understanding non-verbal cues will develop your ability to use them more effectively during your presentations.

While speaking, listening, reading, or writing, we consciously use words to receive or send ideas. Why do we use words? Because they are the primary symbolic forms that convey our thoughts. On paper, words remain static; punctuation marks are used to convey pauses, expressions, emotions, etc. But in face-to-face communication the message is conveyed on two levels simultaneously. One is verbal and the other is non-verbal. For example, you are congratulating two of your friends on their success in their interviews. If you extend your hand to them with a big smile on your face along with your utterance, 'Congrats', your appreciation has more impact on them than the word in isolation. Your smile and the handshake are non-verbal means of communication, which enhance the impact of your verbal communication. Sigmund Freud established the power of non-verbal communication when he stated, 'He that has eyes to see and ears to hear may convince himself that no mortal can keep a secret. If his lips are silent he chats with his fingertips; betrayal oozes out of him at every pore'.

The non-verbal part of an oral presentation is not as deliberate and conscious as verbal communication. Rather, it is subtle and instinctive. Non-verbal communication refers to all communication that occurs without the use of words either



spoken or written. Non-verbal communication is concerned with body movements (Kinesics), space (Proxemics) and vocal features (paralinguistic features). It is important that we know more about these features of body language because the verbal components of oral communication carry less than 35 percent of the social meaning of the situation, while more than 65 percent is carried on the non-verbal band. People react strongly to what they see.

.anguage

speaker presents himself, we see him before we start hearing him. Immediately, we begin developing sions of his abilities and attitudes based on the non-verbal signals he sends. This is why body ge is so critical in oral communication.

anguage includes every aspect of your appearance, from what you wear, how you stand, look, and lo your facial expressions, and physical habits such as nodding your head, jingling change in your or pulling your necktie. Your use of space and gestures are other key concerns.

Personal Appearance

Personal appearance plays an important role; people see you before they hear you. As you adapt your language to an audience, you should also dress appositely. Appearance includes clothes, hair, jewellery, cosmetics, and so on. In today's society the purpose of clothing has altered from fulfilling a basic need to expressing oneself. Clothes accent the body's movements.

You should expect appearance to be a part of the message you communicate. Plan your appearance in such a way that it communicates effectively to others. Even before the speaker utters his first syllable you begin to form an opinion about him and visualize the way he is going to talk. One's appearance may put the audience into a resistant or hostile attitude or induce in them a receptive mood. You should be clean and well groomed, conforming to the need of the occasion. Appearances communicate how we feel about ourselves and how we want to be viewed.

Posture

Posture generally refers to the way we hold ourselves when we stand, sit, or walk. Novice speakers are unsure of what to do with their body. Certain mannerisms creep in, usually from nervousness—pacing constantly, bobbing the shoulders, fidgeting with notes, jingling coins, either constantly moving or remaining static. Truly, what one speaks is very important but what you do just before you begin and after you have finished is equally important.

You need to analyse the effects of body shape and posture to understand their role in non-verbal communication. When you are with your friends you are probably spontaneous. You are unaware of your posture, being fluid in all of your physical movements. But when you encounter an unfamiliar situation, you become more conscious of your posture. Stiff, unnatural positions such as the *big* leaf (hands crossed below the waist with the back of the hand toward the audience) send the message that you are unsure of yourself and your message. Instead, lower your hands to your sides in a natural, relaxed, and resting posture. Standing, sitting, or walking in a relaxed way is a positive posture, which will encourage questions and discussion. Also being comfortably upright, squarely facing an audience, and evenly distributing your weight are all aspects of posture that communicate professionalism, confidence, attention to detail, and organization. Seeing is believing; so be and appear at ease. Neither remain static nor fidget. Move occasionally to hold attention, suggest transitions, and increase emphasis. The way you sit, stand, or walk reveals a lot about you:

- Slumped posture—low spirits
- Erect posture—high spirits, energy, and confidence
- Lean forward—open, honest, and interested
- Lean backward—defensive or disinterested
- Crossed arms—defensive and not ready to listen
- Uncrossed arms—willingness to listen

Ways to Improve Body Language

Try and videotape a part of your presentation. Play it back and identify one aspect of your body language you want to improve. After more rehearsal, record this part again and see if there is any improvement. You can also practise in front of a mirror to improve on facial expressions. When you have worked through your entire presentation, and feel sufficiently confident, invite a friend to watch your performance. Ask him for comments on aspects of your body language that are good or need improving.

Gesture

Gesture is the movement made by hands, arms, shoulders, head, and torso. Adroit gestures can add to the impact of a speech. A well-timed gesture not only drives a point home but also enhances the impact and adds greater value to what is being said. Similarly, an ungainly gesture (like playing with your key chain or button) can mar the effectiveness of the message.

Gestures clarify your ideas or reinforce them and should be well suited to the audience and occasion. Gestures are more numerous than any forms of non-verbal communication, and the meanings attached to them are diverse. It has been observed that there are as many as 700,000 varied hand gestures alone, (Ray L. Birdwhistell, Introduction to Kinesics, Louisville, Ky. University of

it Locker No.

Louisville Press, 1952), and the meanings derived from them may vary from individual to individual.

Gestures should not divert the attention of the listener and distract from your message. Your gesture should be quite natural and spontaneous. Be aware of and avoid irritating gestures like playing with a ring, twisting a key chain, clasping the hands tightly, or cracking your knuckles. Gestures can roughly be divided into the following types:

- Enumerative—numbers
- Descriptive—size of the objects
- Symbolic—abstract concepts
- Locative—location of an object
- Emphatic—emphasis

Facial Expression

Some facial expressions are common to all cultures. Even if you have never met a person from a particular culture, you can recognise certain feelings or attitudes. These are love, happiness, and mirth; surprise; anger and determination; contempt and disgust; fear and suffering.

Along with posture and gesture, facial expressions also play an important part. The face is the most expressive part of your body. A smile stands for friendliness, a frown for discontent, raised eyebrows for disbelief, tightened jaw muscles for antagonism, etc. Facial expressions are subtle. You can use them in a variety of ways: to aid or inhibit or complement your communication. The face rarely sends a single message at a time. Instead it sends a series of messages—your facial expressions may show anxiety, recognition, hesitation, and pleasure in quick succession.

Facial expression is difficult to interpret. Though there are only five basic expressions, you can have 33 blends. (Pearce, C. Glenn et al., 1988, Business Communication: Principles and Application, Second edn, page 590, USA, John Wiley and sons.) Also, people tend to hide their true feelings and reveal only those expressions required at a particular movement. The five basic expressions are:

- Inhibited—restricted and stolid
- Uninhibited—spontaneous and impetuous
- Substitute—happy with a long face
- Frozen—no change in expression
- Blank—no expression at all

Eye Contact

The eyes are considered to be the windows of the soul. You look to the eyes of a speaker to help find out the truthfulness of his speech, his intelligence, attitudes, and feelings. Eye contact is a direct and powerful form of non-verbal communication. You use your eyes to cull information. Your eyes are a rich source of feedback.

Looking directly at listeners builds rapport. Prolonging the eye contact for three to five seconds (without, however, giving the impression of staring) tells the audience

that you are sincere in what you say and that you want them to pay attention. Eye contact is especially important when you start the presentation, and at the beginning of each new section.

Your upper eye lids and eyebrows help you to convey an intricate array of non-verbal messages. Arabs, Latin Americans, and South Europeans look directly into eyes. Asians and Africans maintain far less eye contact. In the professional world you should make personal and pleasant eye contact with the listeners. It is not only that you should look at the audience, how you look at them also counts. Do not look outside the windows, towards the roof or floor, or at one particular section; instead try to establish eye contact with one and all. Your eye contact shows your intensity and elicits a feeling of trust. A direct look conveys candour and openness. This direct and powerful form is a signal for confidence or sincerity; therefore, experienced speakers maintain longer eye contact. Your eyes should convey the message, 'I am pleased to talk with you, believe deeply in what I am saying'.

Eye contact and eye movement help you tremendously in the filtering process or in getting the desired response or feedback. However, be wary of cultural differences when addressing a foreign audience as signals vary from one culture to another.

PROXEMICS

Proxemics is the study of physical space in interpersonal relations. Space is related to behavioural norms. The way people use space tells you a lot about them. In a professional setting, space is used to signal power and status. For instance, the head of a company has a larger office than more junior employees, and you, as a speaker, will have an open space before you when addressing an audience. You should use the psychological power of this space to your advantage.

Your gestures should be in accordance with the space available. When you have plenty of space to manoeuvre, move more boldly and expand your gestures. When seated at a table, use milder gestures. Even here, though, you can subtly reach out over the table to extend your space. This expresses control and authority.

Moving closer to an audience is useful to invite discussion, to express agreement or to emphasize a point. However, do not retreat from this close position when you make an important point or conclude your presentation. This encourages the audience to downplay the importance of your point.

You can learn a great deal about how to use space to great advantage by observing dynamic, influential speakers. It is interesting to note that like kinesics, proxemics also has cultural variations. A Latin American or a French is likely to stand closer to another person when conversing than an Anglo-Saxon would in the same situation. Americans, addressed from a close distance, may feel offended

or become aggressive. Studies show that Americans, unlike many other nationals, avoid close contact with one another in public places.

Edward T. Hall in his *The Hidden Dimension* divides space into four distinct zones.

(i) Intimate: This zone starts with personal touch and extends just to 18 inches (one and a half feet). Members of the family, lovers, spouses, relatives and parents fall under this zone. The best relationship that describes it is the mother-child relationship. No words are spoken; if at all something is spoken, it is just some whispering sounds. Other individuals come close for a very brief period and only under special circumstances—when they want to congratulate you, sympathize with you, or console you. A handshake, a pat on the back, or a hug all come into this zone.

(ii) Personal: This zone stretches from 18 inches (one and a half feet) to 4 feet. Your close friends, colleagues, peers, etc. fall in this tier. Instead of whispering sounds or utter silence, normal talking takes place. Though this zone is personal, it is quite a relaxed and casual place. It permits spontaneous and unprogrammed communication. Sitting or standing so close brings you closer to the listener and gives the impression of friendliness and warmth.

(iii) Social: Social events take place in this radius of 4 feet to 12 feet. In this layer, relationships are more official. You tend to become more formal. People are more cautious in their movements. You should be smart enough to conduct it with less emotion and more planning. Here the number of people decides whether it should be sitting-sitting or sitting-standing position. It is through experience that you decide which position to take. If the number of people is less and you can maintain eye contact, you could go in for a sitting position. If you have to be authoritative and the audience is large, you can go for the sitting-standing position.

(iv) Public: This zone starts from 12 feet and may extend to 30 feet or to the range of eyesight and hearing. Events that take place in this zone are formal. Here the audience views what is happening as an impartial observer. The degree of detachment is very high. The audience is free to do whatever it feels like. Here the speaker has to raise his voice to communicate to others or use a microphone. Public figures like the Prime Minister of a country, for example, have to maintain this distance for security reasons.

PARALINGUISTICS

Paralinguistic features are non-verbal vocal cues that help you to give urgency to your voice. Your voice is your trademark; it is that part of yourself that adds human touch to your words. Writing does not have that immediacy because the words are static on a page. Voice gives extra life to your delivery. Therefore, you

may find it useful to understand the characteristic nuances of voice, namely *quality, volume, rate, pitch, articulation, pronunciation*, and *pauses*.

Projection

Loudness and projection are two different aspects of our voices. It is possible to project your voice without being loud. Stage actors do this when they speak in a low voice, and yet are heard in the back rows of a theatre. If you begin speaking in a loud voice, you will get the full attention of the audience. Then shifting to a lower, softer voice when appropriate will hold that attention. Generally, you need to use a louder voice at the beginning of your talk and at the start of each new section.

To make your voice travel through the room, breathe deeply. You need air in your lungs to project. Often, speakers run out of air and let their voices fade just when they are delivering critical information. At the end of a section, your voice need not be loud, but it must project.

Quality

Quality is a characteristic that distinguishes one voice from another. Each one of us has a unique voice and its quality depends upon its resonating mechanism. While the quality of one's voice cannot be changed, it can be trained for optimum impact. It may be rich and resonant, soft and alluring, thin and nasal, hoarse and husky, or harsh and irritating. Very few people are naturally blessed with deep and resonant quality; everybody can improve upon the quality of the voice and develop it to its fullest potential. Abraham Lincoln and Winston Churchill, for example, adapted the quality of their voices to become speakers par excellence.

Volume

Volume is the loudness or the softness of the voice. Your voice should always project but need not always be loud. If the place you are speaking in is large and open, the volume should be high, and if the place is small and enclosed, the volume should be low. If your volume is too high you may sound boorish and insensitive, whereas if it is too low you may convey an impression of timidity, which has no place in the business world. It also gives the impression that you are not well prepared and lack the confidence to express yourself. In all, you should vary your volume so as to make your voice audible and clear.

One way to improve your voice and speaking style is through reading aloud. Read children's stories, giving each character a unique way of speaking, to develop vocal variety. Reciting tongue twisters such as *she sells sea shells on the seashore* also improves diction.

Pace/Rate

Rate is the number of words which you speak per minute. It varies from person to person and from 80 to 250 words per minute. The normal rate is from 120 to 150

words. Cultivate your pace so as to fit in this reasonable limit. If a person speaks too slowly and monotonously, he is most likely to be considered a dull speaker even though the contents of his speech may be highly interesting. Similarly, a fast speaker also causes discomfort because the listeners do not get time to grasp the thoughts and switch from one thought to another. Under these circumstances, listeners may just stop listening to you and their attention may go astray.

It is best, therefore, to vary your speaking pace. Use pauses to create emphasis. A well-paced, varied message suggests enthusiasm, self-assurance and awareness of audience.

Pitch

Pitch refers to the number of vibrations per second of your voice. The rise and fall of the voice conveys various emotions. 'Thank you' is such a phrase. You can find out the difference when you utter it indifferently and when you say it with sincerity. *Inflections* give warmth, lustre, vitality, and exuberance to your speech. Lowness of pitch can indicate sadness, shock, dullness, guilt, etc. If you are excited, joyous, ecstatic, triumphant, and even angry, then your pitch automatically becomes high. A well-balanced pitch results in a clear and effective tone. It helps you avoid being monotonous. *Intonation* refers to the rising and falling pitch of the voice when somebody says a word or syllable. By learning and adopting an appropriate intonation pattern, you will be able to express your intention very clearly.

Pitch is also influenced by your air supply; if you run out of air, you cannot control the pitch of your voice. Like the strings of a guitar, if you tense the vocal chords, a higher pitch results, and if you relax the vocal chords, a lower pitch results. Tilting your chin up or down reduces your ability to control pitch.

Use a variety of pitches to hold your listeners' attention. Avoid raising the pitch of you voice as your end a sentence. This vocal pattern, called *pitching up*, makes your remarks sound tentative or unfinished.

Articulation

Speakers should be careful not to slop, slur, chop, truncate, or omit sounds between words or sentences. If all the sounds are not uttered properly, the flow of understanding gets interrupted and deters the listener from grasping the meaning of the message. The result is similar to the negative impression that written errors leave with a reader. Lazy articulation, slurred sounds, or skipping over words will lower the credibility of the speaker. Develop in yourself the ability to speak distinctly; produce the sounds in a crisp and lucid manner without causing any *ob*fuscation. Your audience will better understand *'I do not know'* and *'I want to go'* than *'I dunno'* and *'I wanna go'*.

Pronunciation

If *articulation* means speaking out all the sounds distinctly, then *pronunciation* requires us to speak out sounds in way that is generally accepted. The best way is to follow British Received Pronunciation. (Received pronunciation or R.P., or Educated Southern British English, is a form of English socially acceptable in all parts of the country.) One should be careful enough to pronounce individual sounds along with word-stress according to the set norms. Don't be taken in by the fancy that you know the correct pronunciation of all the words. Wherever there is confusion, always consult a good dictionary and try to pronounce it accordingly. Given below are few commonly mispronounced words along with their correct pronunciation:

Word	Common Error	Correct Pronunciation
arctic	ar-tic	arc-tic
gesture	ges-ture	jes-ture
3 tier	3-tyre	3-tear
gigantic	jai-jan-tik	jai-gan-tik

Voice Modulation

While intonation refers to the tonal variations, modulation pertains to the way we regulate, vary, or adjust the tone, pitch, and volume of the sound or speaking voice. Modulation of voice brings flexibility and vitality to your voice, and you can express emotions, sentiments like impatience, careful planning, despondency, suspicion, etc. in the best possible way. If you do not pay special attention to the modulation of your voice, then your voice becomes flat and you emerge as a languid speaker with no command over your voice. Word stress and sentence stress also play an important role in voice modulation. For example, by accentuating one or two words in a sentence (e.g., in the sentence *This company produces 50 cars everyday*, you can stress 'this' and '50 cars'), you can effectively bring in modulation in your voice. If you are a novice in professional presentations, it is better to initially underline the words that you may like to stress during your presentation. This will help you to avoid sounding dull and monotonous.

Pauses

A pause is a short silence flanked by words. A pause in speaking lets the listener reflect on the message and digest it accordingly. It helps you glide from one thought to another one. It embellishes your speech because it is a natural process to give a break. Be spontaneous. If you become too self-conscious, this process becomes artificial.

with accrued interest will be worked out on the date of payment.)

A pause helps not only the listener but the speaker as well. Pauses automatically come in between the major points of your speech. Do not prolong the pauses unnecessarily as they will hinder the flow of your speech. Vocalized pauses or vocal segregates like *uh, ah, hm, ahem, a, aah* should be substituted by silent pauses. Vocalized pauses make the speech sound evasive and untruthful, they dilute the conviction of your point. If you keep inserting repetitive phrases like *'I mean', 'well', 'like', 'ok', 'got it', 'actually'*, etc., then these phrases sweep away the good impression you have created. Use pauses thoughtfully, and time them well as they exhibit assurance, confidence, and self-control. Use pauses at the end of certain thought units to let the audience fully absorb the information.

3 CHRONEMICS

Chronemics is the study of how human beings communicate through their use of time. How do you communicate with others? What does time mean to you? In order to use time as an effective communication tool, you should understand the impact it has and then act accordingly. We attempt to control time, trying to use it more effectively.

In the professional world, time is a valuable commodity. When you are late for an appointment, people react negatively. If you arrive early, you are considered either over-eager or aggressive. So always be on time. Through time, you communicate both subtly and explicitly.

People have their own 'time language'. To one person who wakes up at 8:00 a.m., 6:30 a.m. may be early; to another, 8: 00 a.m. may be late if he wakes up at 5:00 a.m. every day!

Time language also varies from culture to culture. In Latin countries, meetings usually begin well after their appointed time. Everyone knows this. It is customary, and no one is offended by the delay. In Scandinavia or Germany, on the other hand, strict punctuality is the rule, and tardiness is frowned upon.

As a speaker, your awareness of schedules is a chronemic element. Good timing is crucial, and you should rehearse a formal presentation until it is a little under line, because staying within time limits is a mark of courtesy and professionalism. If, at the beginning of your presentation, you assure the listeners that you will be giving them time at the end of your presentation and then keep talking till the time is all gone, without allowing scope for the audience to respond, you will undoubtedly annoy the audience.

The shorter the time allowed, the more difficult the task. The more difficult the task, the greater the need not just for careful planning and effective visual aids but also for diligent rehearsal.

To recapitulate, oral presentation is an art that requires careful planning, preparation, and a great deal of practice. This tool is both valuable and relevant. Apart from communicating the main purpose of your presentation, there are various factors that you need to blend inextricably to convey your message clearly. These features are: audience analysis, organization of matter, preparation of an outline, nuances of delivery, kinesics and paralinguistics, and visual aids. Your aim should be to keep all these threads intact, neither too loose nor too tight. With care and practice, you can achieve wonders with your oral presentations.

SAMPLE SPEECH

Given below is the full text of a sample presentation (of about 20 minutes duration) given by a student on the topic 'Internet Search Engines: Demystified'. Certain comments are provided so that you can appreciate how effectively the speaker uses the theory discussed in this chapter. At the end of the text the PowerPoint slides which the speaker used for the presentation are also given.

Internet Search Engines: Demystified

Imagine a huge library without a catalogue or a superhighway without a road map. What would you do? How will you find out a book that you badly need, or how would you locate a place that you are looking for. Without a catalogue you might not even dare to enter the library however well stocked it may be, and without a roadmap you may be in a maze. *(The speaker grabs the attention of the audience by posing some questions.)*

You've heard the Internet referred to as the information superhighway. As you all know, Internet has fast become the largest source of information. Today it is the most essential as well as the most happening commodity in our everyday life. It is just impossible to imagine the present-day world without the *world wide web*. The range of topics the Internet covers is so wide that when people say *anything under the sun*, it is no exaggeration. But to be able to take proper advantage of this, you should be familiar with this wonder world and should also know how to go about looking into it for what you want. And Internet is the biggest library in the world. When it started, there was no way to navigate around it—no signs, no route maps, and certainly no stoplights. That's changed. Today there are lots of maps you can use. Of course, they are not called 'maps'. They are called search engines (Slide 1). These engines help us in finding whatever we want. The only problem is that sometimes these engines *fail* to understand what we are looking for. But once we make it clear to them, the information we are seeking is in front of our eyes in an instant. In order to use them efficiently, we need to know what these search engines are and how they work. *(The speaker relates the topic to the audience's interest by using 'you' and also by emphasizing the need for understanding the topic.)*

Interviews

INTRODUCTION

An interview is a psychological and sociological instrument. It is an interaction between two or more persons for a specific purpose, in which the interviewer asks the interviewee specific questions in order to assess his suitability for recruitment, admission, or promotion, or for an opinion. It is a systematized method of contact with a person to know his views and is regarded as the most important method of data collection. In short, an interview is a two party conversation in which at least one party has a specific serious purpose.

There are not many of us who can remain unaffected by the idea of facing an interview. Nevertheless, you unknowingly pass through interview situations very frequently in your life. For example when you visit your doctor or lawyer you are in an interview situation. Similarly, when your boss calls you to discuss certain issues before recommending you for a promotion, you participate in an interview. Several such situations happen all the time and you deal with them effortlessly, unconsciously. However, while facing a formal interview, say, for admission or for a job, you are under much more stress, since so much hinges upon your successful performance. Such interviews need a lot of preparation.

OBJECTIVES

The conduct of an interview depends very much on the reason behind it. Generally, interviews are conducted to achieve some of the following objectives:

- to select a person for a specific task
- to monitor performance
- to collect information
- to exchange information
- to counsel

TYPES OF INTERVIEWS

Depending on their objective and nature, interviews can be categorized into the following types:

- Job
- Information
- Persuasive
- Exit
- Evaluation
- Counselling
- Conflict-resolution
- Disciplinary
- Termination

Each type calls for a slightly different approach. For example, in a job interview *you* may have to convince the interviewer that you're the best person for the job, whereas in a termination interview your *employer* may have to convince you that your services have been terminated for reasons that are specific, accurate and verifiable.

When we compare the involvement and contribution of the interviewer and the interviewee, there emerge three basic types of interview: *telling, telling and listening,* and *problem solving.* In a *telling* interview the flow of communication is almost entirely one way—downwards. It is used most effectively in a directing, time-constrained situation; but it can cause hostility and defensive behaviour when the employee does not have the opportunity to participate. In a *telling and listening* interview, more feedback from the subordinate is allowed, but the interviewer still maintains control over the flow of communication. In a *problem-solving* interview the flow of communication is two-way. The bulk of communication is upwards, a genuine rapport is established, ideas are pooled, and change facilitated.

Job interviews. Here, the candidate wants to learn about the position and the organization; the employer wants to learn about the applicant's abilities and experience. Both hope to make a good impression and to establish rapport. In the initial round, job interviews are usually formal and structured. But later, interviews may be relatively spontaneous as the interviewer explores the candidate's responses.

Information interviews. The interviewer seeks facts that bear on a decision or contribute to basic understanding. Information flows mainly in one direction:

one person asks a list of questions that must be covered and listens to the answers supplied by the other person, e.g., doctor–patient, boss–subordinate.

Persuasive interviews. One person tells another about a new idea, product, or service and explains why the other should act on his or her recommendations. Persuasive interviews are often associated with, but are certainly not limited to, selling. The persuader asks about the other person's needs and shows how the product or concept is able to meet those needs. These persuasive interviews require skill in drawing out and listening to others as well as the ability to impart information.

Exit interviews. The interviewer tries to understand why the interviewee is leaving the organization or transferring to another department or division. A departing employee can often provide insight into whether the business is being handled efficiently or whether things could be improved. The interviewer tends to ask all the questions while the interviewee provides answers. Encouraging the employee to focus on events and processes rather than on personal gripes will elicit more useful information for the organization.

Evaluation interviews. A supervisor periodically gives an employee feedback on his or her performance. The supervisor and the employee discuss progress towards predetermined standards or goals and evaluate areas that require improvement. They may also discuss goals for the coming year, as well as the employee's longer-term aspirations and general concerns.

Counselling interviews. A supervisor talks with an employee about personal problems that are interfering with work performance. The interviewer is concerned with the welfare of both the employee and the organization. The goal is to establish the facts, convey the company's concern, and steer the person towards a source of help. (Only a trained professional should offer advice on problems such as substance abuse, marital tension, and financial trouble.)

Conflict-resolution interviews. Two competing people or groups of people with opposing points of view (such as Smith versus Jones, day shift versus night shift, General Motors versus the United Auto Workers) explore their problems and attitudes. The goal is to bring the two parties closer together, cause adjustments in perceptions and attitudes, and create a more productive climate.

Disciplinary interviews. A supervisor tries to correct the behaviour of an employee who has ignored the organization's rules and regulations. The interviewer tries to get the employee to see the reason for the rules and to agree to comply. The interviewer also reviews the facts and explores the person's attitude. Because of the emotional reaction that is likely, neutral observations are more effective than critical comments.

Termination interviews. A supervisor informs an employee of the reasons for the termination of the latter's job. The interviewer tries to avoid involving the company in legal action and tries to maintain as positive a relationship as possible

with the interviewee. To accomplish these goals, the interviewer gives reasons that are specific, accurate, and verifiable.

In your profession you may come across most of the types of interviews mentioned above. At present, as you may require a more detailed account of job interviews, we have discussed the various aspects of this type of interview such as employer's expectations, certain critical success and failure factors, preparation, process, follow-up, and guidelines.

JOB INTERVIEWS

Job interviews can be either *face-to-face* or *telephonic.*

Face-to-face

Employer's expectations

Your prospective employer might be looking for the following qualities in you when you appear for an interview:

- **Disposition.** Appearance, clothes, facial expressions, gestures, manners, the way you present yourself, the impression you leave on the employer—all these things are components of your personality. Therefore, you must ensure that you present yourself in a manner that leaves a lasting impression.
- **Career Objective.** The interview panel will be trying to gauge what you want to pursue in your life. You may also be asked where you want to see yourself after 10 years. The panel will try to evaluate your current occupation, stated objectives, consistency, and reasons for change. You should be clear about your career objective and should be able to clearly convey the same to the employer by linking the priorities in your life with your background and aptitude.
- **Subject Knowledge.** Every employer expects that the prospective employees are well versed with the subjects they had pursued in the past or are currently pursuing. Hence the employer will be interested in assessing the subjects of your study, which are related to your job. So you must brush up the fundamentals of your subject/s or any specialization you have pursued. Any shift in terms of area or subject also needs to be explained.
- **General Knowledge.** A good general awareness is the primary requisite of a candidate aspiring for a job today. The employer tries to assess your curiosity about what's happening all around you, your analytical ability, your mental level, and your potential for coherent perception of multiple happenings. The panel may ask questions ranging from the coup in a country to the announcement of an award to a film. The way you tackle each question is very important. It is necessary to feel confident and develop a positive frame of mind.

- **Communication Skill.** Communicating effectively is vital for both personal and organizational growth. The employer will try to assess how effective you are in communicating your ideas to him, both verbally and non-verbally, and how intensely you can listen and comprehend.
- **Mental Agility.** The ability to quickly grasp the question and reply appropriately is a sign of mental alertness. This quality implies quick thinking, presence of mind, and quick response. The interviewer may judge your mental agility by asking an odd question or by making a tricky remark. He could also assess you by the observations you make when he presents you with a practical problem. You can improve this quality by developing the art of concentration. Playing carrom or chess, solving puzzles, reading witty and humorous plays, and conversing with intelligent people will help in developing this quality.
- **Consistency.** A good candidate has a positive, definite, and well-developed approach to life. He will stick to his opinion and make judicious decisions. He will not be moved by emotions and external impressions. The interviewer may ask the same question in a disguised form later in the interview to check your opinion. Never contradict yourself.
- **Self-confidence.** This is the most essential requirement of a good candidate. Self-confidence means trust in yourself. This generates self-esteem and self-respect. By possessing will power, socializing, identifying your shortcomings, fighting fear and nervousness, having a positive approach, and acting as a leader, you can boost your self-confidence.

Ten Success Factors

Taking the right courses, holding good grades, and having related work experience are all important selection criteria. But they do not matter much if you do not project the qualities that organizations look for.

The truth is that most interviewers seek individuals who are able to present themselves well in a face-to-face interview. They seek to recommend those who will be a good reflection upon themselves and their selection skills. So most interviewers naturally gravitate to specific 'critical success factors' that have worked for them consistently.

The following are ten critical success factors nearly every company is looking for:

- Positive attitude towards work
- Proficiency in the field of study
- Communication skills (oral and written)
- Interpersonal skills
- Confidence
- Critical thinking and problem-solving skills
- Flexibility
- Self-motivation

- Leadership
- Teamwork

Show your competence in as many of the above critical success factors as possible and you will rise above the competition.

Ten Failure Factors

There may be many reasons why you could be turned down for a job. The following are ten common reasons for a candidate being rejected. Beware of them.

- Arrogance
- Apathy
- Uninhibited nervousness
- Equivocation
- Lack of concentration
- Lack of crispness
- Lack of social skills
- Lack of firmness
- Inadequate quantitative/qualitative skills
- Unsuitable personality

Preparation

'Determine that the thing can and shall be done and then we shall find the way.'

Abraham Lincoln

Successful interviews begin with preparation. Read this section again to be fully prepared before your first interview. Develop a positive attitude. The key to success in an interview is not your experience, your grades, what classes you took, your extracurricular activities, or any other basic necessities. Those skills are what got you the interview. The key element can be summed up in one word: *attitude*. If you want to rise above others with better experience, better grades or better skills, you will need to work on developing a highly positive work attitude. The way most employers differentiate at the entry level is by the candidates' attitude towards work. They look for those who have the *can do attitude* and are sincerely willing to put forth their very best effort.

Go Through a Mock Interview The mock interview is more than just a chance to work out your interview jitters. It is an opportunity to practice your interviewing technique and answers live. It is also a chance to hear constructive feedback from someone who can guide you towards improving your style and presentation during the real interview. Just one mock interview will bring about a marked improvement in your interview skills. Ideally, have the mock session videotaped. That way you will have two opinions—the mock interviewer's and your own. Go through at least one mock interview. For maximum effectiveness, review your answers and then go through a second mock interview. This will give you confidence in your first real interview.

Gather Adequate Inside Information The very best thing you can do to prepare for an interview with a specific company is to interview someone who is already on the inside. You can use your network to find out any one whom you know. Ideally, this would be an individual who went straight out of your institution into the company—the more recent, the better. If this is impossible then gather information on your own. The company website, annual report, newspaper articles, etc. will all provide you with information you need about it—the company's unique strength, mission, primary issues of focus within, profitability, quality control and improvement, global market, important people, interview process, etc. Note that the depth of information you can collect beforehand is far greater than what you can get in the course of interview. And it will give you an edge over others in the interview.

You should also take a critical look at the information you have about the job. Just as you have structured your resume to show your qualifications, skills, and experience in the best possible light, so too has the company's advertisement for the job structured it in the most attractive manner.

Look at it from several angles: are there any hidden snags or unanswered questions—anything that may lead to regret later if you get the job? Make a list of questions you want to ask, phrasing them in a non-controversial manner. During the interview, you will be invited to ask questions. You can use this list at that point. It will show how carefully you have prepared for the interview and how serious you are about the job.

Dress Appropriately Campus fashions and work fashions are two different worlds. You should be doing the talking; not your clothes. Select conservative, good quality clothes. They should be neat, clean, and ironed. Make sure your shoes are conservative, clean, and polished. Arrange all your documents systematically in a briefcase or neat folder and carry it with you.

Be Prepared to Ask Questions Interviewers expect you to come in with a working knowledge of the company as well as with a list of questions. When you've really done your homework you may not be able to think of any questions because you already have the company's history. Still, make up some questions ahead of time to ask during the interview. They can be based on the job that you are applying for or your prospects in that job.

Questions which you can ask the interviewer:

- Whom will I report to?
- Whom will I be working with?
- What training opportunities are there?
- What promotional prospects are there?
- When will you be making a final decision?

Memorize Your Resume Imagine the embarrassment if your interviewer asks you to elaborate on the project which you had done during your course of study, and you fumble. For every item on your resume, try to have a paragraph's worth of information in addition to what is already said; even better, try to think of a way in which each item illustrates one of your particular strengths or weaknesses. If you are too nervous to remember everything, it is all right to hold a copy of your resume in your hand to jog your memory. But do not forget to continue making eye contact with your interviewer.

Be Punctual The waiting room is your initial face-to-face connection point with your potential employer. Always arrive at least ten to fifteen minutes early. This will give you the time necessary to do a quick mental review before the actual interview. Have a glass of water to avoid the 'cottonmouth' syndrome. Check in with the secretary or administrator. Ask how long the interview is scheduled for, so you have an idea of how much time you'll have.

Relax By the time interview day rolls around, you should be set. Get a good night's sleep, eat well, and take a relaxing walk beforehand. And remember, it is just one job. If you do not get it, it is not the end of the world—it just means that fate may have even a better opportunity for you waiting around the corner.

Types of Questions Interview questions may either be open-ended or close-ended. There are basically five types of questions you may face during the course of an interview.

1. **Experience Questions**
   The main purpose of this type of question is to place objective measurements on features of your background:
   e.g., What is your C.G.P.A. (Cumulative Grade Point Average) ? How long were you at...?
2. **Credential Questions**
   This type of question aims at subjectively evaluating features of your background:
   e.g., What did you learn in your network programming class? What were your responsibilities in that position?
3. **Opinion Questions**
   This type aims at analysing subjectively how you would respond in a series of scenarios:
   e.g., What would you do in this situation? What are your strengths and weaknesses?
4. **Dumb Questions**
   These questions are asked to find out if you are capable of an original thought:
   e.g., Can you sell this pen to me in one minute? What kind of animal would you like to be?

5. **Behavioural Questions**
The purpose of this type of question is to anticipate future responses based upon your past behaviour:
e.g., Can you give me a specific example of how you did that? What were the steps you followed to accomplish that task?
Behavioural questions are gaining greater acceptance by the trained interviewers because past performance is the most reliable indicator of future results.

6. **Difficult Questions**
Good interviewers often ask difficult questions. This is because they have to establish the weaknesses as well as strengths of each candidate.
Look at your CV from the interviewer's perspective. List out the gaps, weaknesses, and any problems you can see. If you were the interviewer, what would you ask? Work out your answer to each question.

Process

Three Basic Steps In its simplest form, an interview consists of three distinct steps:

- Establishing rapport
- Gathering information
- Closing

Understanding and successful completion of these basic steps are critical for you to go onto the next step in the process, whether that be another interview or the actual job offer.

Establishing Rapport The rapport-establishing step is where the vital first impressions are formed. Some employers may claim to be able to make a decision about a candidate in 30 seconds or less. The truth is that you set the tone for the interview through your physical appearance and initial responses. When you enter the room, look around and establish eye contact with the people there. Smile warmly and greet them. Shake hands with a firm grip, if required, and sit when invited to do so.

Interviewers will analyse you in reference to the company culture. Further, your initial responses will greatly affect how you are perceived in the eyes of the interviewer. It is not necessarily the words you say, but how you say them. This is where your positive attitude and confidence will establish the tone for the interview. And this is the step during which you may be able to make your personal connection with the interviewer.

Information Gathering At this stage, the employers will be asking questions and matching your answers against the critical success factors we have discussed earlier in this chapter. Some may be close-ended while others will be open-ended. Your honesty and sincerity in answering should be evident. Most interviewees are keenly

aware of when they are being snowed. The questions in this step will usually be probing questions which drill deep into your background, attempting to get past the interview veneer. In fact this is the stage in which you will need to consolidate the employer's view. You will be judged on attitude, work ethic (will you really work hard or are you just looking for a cushy job?), intelligence, and honesty.

Closing If your interview was successful, there will usually be an indication of what is to come next. You may be given further company information which is reserved only for the select few. No matter what your view of the interview is up to this point, it is important to personally close the interview by establishing continuity of the process. Make certain you understand the next step and be prepared to follow up from your side. Always pursue each interview as if it were your last.

Answering Techniques

1. Behavioural Answering Technique
- Talk about how you had done rather than how you would do.
- Be prepared to use examples from your work, classes, and extracurricular activities.
- Be ready to offer not just any example, but your own example.

2. Compelling Story Technique
- Expand your answers by developing the specific examples into compelling stories with personality, flair, and interest.
- Captivate your interviewer by providing the details and nuances that bring your story to life.
- Do not, however, be tempted into lengthy monologues that will stretch the interviewer's time.

3. Personality Matching Technique
- Take your cue from the interviewer in terms of tone and approach. Do not be too casual, even if the interviewer seems to be. Watch and Learn.
- Bring under control the 'too much' area (too loud, too pushy, too cocky, too egoistical, too stuffy, etc.) in your own personality.

4. Parroting Technique
- Do not assume or make a 'best guess' of what the interviewer is looking for.
- If a question is unclear to you, it is absolutely appropriate to 'parrot back' the question in your own words to make sure you have the correct meaning.
- Use it as a temporary stall when you do not have a ready answer.

5. Reframing Technique
- Always attempt to answer the questions as straightforwardly as possible initially.
- Reframe the original question to illustrate an area of your background that can further enhance your overall image.

Answering 'Problem' Questions

If you are asked an awkward question, you should try to turn this into an advantage. Do not evade the question or lie. Answer in a straightforward manner, dealing briefly with the negative aspects and move on, giving more time to detailing the positive aspects of the situation. Compare these two situations:

A
Mr Sharma: Ms Tyagi, you seem to have worked for just six months at CompuSoft. Why?
Ms Tyagi: They were going through a financial crunch and I was laid off.
Mr Sharma: Why?
Ms Tyagi: I just told you. They were ...
Mr Sharma: No, no, I meant why did they lay you off, and not someone else?

B
Mr Sharma: Ms Pandit, you seem to have worked for just six months at CompuSoft before leaving. Why?
Ms Pandit: They were going through a financial crunch and laid me off. That gave me time to do a course on web design which came in most helpful in my next assignment.
Mr Sharma: Was that at Worldcom?
Ms Pandit: Yes.
Mr Sharma: Tell me more about that.

As you can see, Ms Tyagi has painted herself in a bad light, whereas Ms Pandit has turned a negative point into a positive one by emphasizing the new skill she has acquired.

For example, if you are asked who your favourite professor is, you might give a short answer about a particular professor, then reframe the question by explaining why that professor is your favourite. '... in fact it was her inspiration that encouraged me to participate in a two-week internship over the winter break, where I combined my classroom knowledge with practical experience in the field of ... .' Thus you can use this technique to your advantage in the interview.

Some more tips:

- Ask permission if you wish to take notes.
- Remain calm if you sense prejudice or any preconceived notion on the part of the interviewer. Keeping your cool will keep the situation from getting out of hand.
- Turn off your cell phone. If it goes off accidentally, apologize and turn it off.
- Respond to both verbal and non-verbal cues of the interviewer.
- Ask relevant questions. Avoid becoming familiar or indulging in unnecessary chit-chat or gossip.

6. Abraham Lincoln Technique

- Point to your strengths instead of making excuses for shortcomings.
- First speak (be it grades, work experience, extracurricular activities, etc.) well of others when the interviewer asks why you are lacking in a particular area.
- Then establish your own case.

Abraham Lincoln, while arguing in the court, would usually argue both sides of the case to the jury.

He would first take the opponent's side of the issue and then his client's side.

nfidence is the touchstone of success.'
Vivekananda

Fifty Standard Interview Questions

1. Tell me about yourself.
2. What do you want to do with your life?
3. Do you have any actual work experience?
4. How would you describe your ideal job?
5. Why did you choose this career?
6. When did you decide on this career?
7. What goals do you have in your career?
8. How do you plan to achieve these goals?
9. How do you evaluate success?
10. Describe a situation in which you were successful.
11. What do you think it takes to be successful in this career?
12. What accomplishments have given you the most satisfaction in your life?
13. If you had to live your life over again, what would you change?
14. Would your rather work with information or with people?
15. Are you a team player?
16. What motivates you?
17. Why should I hire you?
18. Are you a goal-oriented person?
19. Tell me about some of your recent goals and what you did to achieve the
20. What are your short-term goals?
21. What is your long-range objective?
22. What do you see yourself doing five years from now?
23. Where do you want to be ten years from now?
24. Do you handle conflict well?
25. Have you ever had a conflict with a boss or professor? How did you resolv
26. What major problem have you had to deal with recently?
27. Do you handle pressure well?
28. What is your greatest strength?
29. What is your greatest weakness?
30. If I were to ask one of your professors to describe you, what would he
say?
31. Why did you choose to attend your college?
32. What changes would you make at your college?
33. How has your education prepared you for your career?
34. What were your favourite classes? Why?
35. Do you enjoy doing independent research?
36. Who were your favourite professors? Why?
37. Why is your GPA (Grade Point Average) not higher?
38. Do you have any plans for further education?

- Appropriately use the top five: non-verbal eye contact (shows interest and confidence), facial expression (tells about your delight and excitement), posture (reveals confidence and power potential), gestures, space (shows your respect to the interviewer and awareness about the organizational culture).
- In the end, restate your interest in the job.
- Smile and say 'thank you'.
- Tell them how you look forward to seeing them again.
- Shake hands firmly.
- Tell them how much you enjoyed the interview.

Telephone Interviews

lephone view is also an view and not a phone call, hence it has to eated with all espect given to e-to-face view.

The telephone has a great deal of power; as a basic business instrument it has proved to be very essential. The first contact many people have with you is over the phone. They will probably form a lasting impression of you on the basis of that conversation. Fortunately, with a little tact and attention to what you say and how you say it, you can use the phone as an effective tool in getting and keeping co-operation, sales, and goodwill.

Many people do not take telephone interviews as seriously as face-to-face interviews. A telephone interview is also an interview and not just a phone call, and hence it has to be treated with all the respect given to a face-to-face interview.

There are *three types* of telephonic interviews:

1. You initiate a call to the hiring manager and they express interest in your background. The call from that point forward is an interview.
2. A company calls you based upon a previous contact. You are likely to be unprepared for the call, but it is still an interview.
3. You have a pre-set time with a company representative to speak further on phone. This is also an interview.

Preparation

There are several things you can do in preparing for a telephone interview, so that you are not caught unawares.

- Keep all of your documents within easy reach of the phone so that you can refer to them. In this respect, you have a major advantage in a phone interview which does not exist in a face-to-face interview.
- Have a note pad and pen to take notes.
- Keep a mirror nearby. Look into that mirror consistently throughout the phone call and smile. You will improve your telephone presence by using this simple technique. You will find yourself coming across much friendlier, more interested, and more alert. If you feel self-conscious about seeing yourself in the mirror, you can use the mirror as an occasional checkpoint. But for most of us, seeing our reflection gives us the kind of feedback necessary to make instant modification towards a more positive presence. When you try this technique, please ensure that you are alone in the room.
- Always stand up when you are talking with a potential employer on the phone. It gets your blood flowing, improves your posture, and improves your response time. It helps give an action perception to your telephone call.
- Try to match your speaking rate and pitch with that of the interviewer. Remember to stay within your personality range, but venture towards that portion of your range which most closely matches that of your interviewer.
- Place a 'Do Not Disturb' note on your door.
- Turn off your stereo, TV, and any other potential distraction.
- Warm up your voice while waiting for the call. Sing an uplifting song to yourself.
- If your phone interview is at a set time, make sure you answer nature's call first.
- Have a glass of water handy, since you will not have a chance to take a break during the call.

Guidelines

When you answer, identify yourself. A 'hello' is not sufficient; give your name and department. By saying 'Vivek Bharghava, Quality Control', you give callers the information they need, and you also prompt them to identify themselves in return. This also shows that you are businesslike and ready to be of service. Apply this rule even when picking up the phone for someone else.

Organize yourself well before you face a telephonic interview. You will hardly have any time to prepare, from the time the interview is fixed and till the time you will actually get the call. You cannot anticipate when you will get the call. Usually the call comes at the worst of times, such as early morning or late evening. Avoid being caught completely off-guard by keeping your resume and a note pad by the telephone.

The most obvious (and often most neglected) point to remember is this: during the interview, the interviewer has only ears to judge you with, and that is something you must exploit. Here are some tips.

Take a Surprise Call in Your Stride If you receive a call as a result of a mailed resume or a telephone message you left, and you are unprepared, be calm. Sound positive, friendly, and collected: 'Thank you for calling, Pranay. Would you wait just a moment while I close the door?' Put the phone down, take three deep breaths to slow your heart down, pull out your resume and a scratch pad to take notes on, put a smile on your face, and pick up the phone again. Now you are in control of yourself and the situation.

Always Refer to the Interviewer by the First Name This is especially valid for interviewers from USA. During the start of the interview, when normal

pleasantries are exchanged, greet the interviewer enthusiastically. Make a conscious effort to infuse enthusiasm and pep in your voice. Allow the company representative to do most of the talking. Keep up your end of the conversation and be sure to ask a few questions of your own that will reveal you as an intelligent person and provide you the opportunity to promote your candidacy. For example, ask what immediate projects the interviewer's department is involved in. When the interviewer answers your question, you will either have a clear picture of how to sell yourself, or you will ask a follow-up question for clarification. For example: 'What specific skills and personality traits do you think are necessary for a person to succeed with those challenges?'

Beware of Giving Yes/No Answers They give no real information about your abilities. Also, try giving answers which give details about you to the interviewers that he or she can ask you more questions. Be factual in your answers. If a situation arises where you are forced to say, 'I do not know', do so gracefully and try and cover up your shortcomings with your strengths by saying, 'I do not know, but I can study that and I am confident that given the opportunity, I can master it in a short span of time.' Do not try to hide your shortcomings, but every time you acknowledge your shortcoming, do it in a positive manner.

Speak Directly into the Telephone Keep the mouthpiece about one inch from your mouth. Do not smoke or eat while talking on the phone.

Take Notes They will be invaluable. Towards the end of the interview you will get an opportunity where the interviewer will invite you to ask questions, if any. You can make good use of your notes here. If, for any reason, the interview is interrupted, jot down the topic under discussion. When he or she gets back on the line, you can helpfully recap: 'We were just discussing ...'. That will be appreciated and will set you apart from the others.

The interviewer may talk about the corporation. A little flattery goes a long way (but do not overdo it): admire the company's achievements and you are, in fact, admiring the interviewer. Likewise, if any areas of common interest arise, comment on them, and agree with the interviewer when possible—people hire people like themselves. If the interviewer does not give you the openings you need to sell yourself, be ready to salvage the situation and turn it to your advantage.

The telephone interview has come to an end when you are asked whether you have any questions. Ask any questions that will improve your understanding of the job requirements. If you have not asked before, now is the time to establish what projects you would be working on in the first six months.

'It sounds like a very interesting opportunity, Pranay, and a situation where I could definitely make a contribution. I am very excited about the project that you just described. I just can't wait to get the good news from you.' (Note: Even though the emphasis throughout has been on putting things in your own words, do use 'make a contribution'. It shows pride in your work—a key personal trait.)

Once the details are confirmed, finish with this request: 'If I need any additional information, can I get back to you?' The company representative will naturally agree. No matter how many questions you get answered in the initial conversation, there will always be something you forgot. This allows you to call again to satisfy any curiosity—it will also enable you to increase rapport. Do not take too much advantage of it, though—one well-placed phone call that contains two or three considered questions will be appreciated; four or five phone calls will not.

In a nutshell:

- Always greet the interviewer with enthusiasm.
- DO NOT answer questions with one word. Try to give details of your area of experience. Keep notes handy. If necessary, prepare a write-up on your responsibilities and refer to it during the interview to make sure that you do not forget anything.
- DO NOT use any words of your native language.
- If you have not understood the question, ask the interviewer politely to repeat/elaborate.
- Avoid repeating yourself.
- DO NOT raise your voice during the interview.
- DO NOT interrupt the interviewer while he is talking.
- When talking about your project, instead of trying to sell the product or your present company's capabilities to him, explain how you went about doing it and sell your capabilities to him.
- If the interviewer appears to be asking trivial or irrelevant questions, take all of them seriously. Maybe he is trying to check your communication skills.
- DO NOT ask any personal questions to the interviewer.
- At the end of the interview, always thank the interviewer for his time.

EXERCISES

1. Write short notes on each of the following terms with special reference to job interviews in about 100 words.

(i) Mental agility
(ii) Unsuitable personality
(iii) Interpersonal skills
(iv) Apathy
(v) Behavioural questions

2. Assume that you are one of the interview panelists who are going to a renowned institution for engineering and technology in India for campus interviews in August 2003. Prepare the plan for your entire interview process including all the types of evaluation components that are required to assess the candidates thoroughly. Invent necessary details.

3. Answer the following questions briefly:

(i) If you wish to switch jobs because you cannot work with your supervisor, how would you explain this to a prospective employer?
(ii) What can you do to create a favourable impression when you discover that an open-ended interview has turned into a stress interview?